less importance to physical bodies, then even AIs that lack any corporeal manifestations may be accepted as legal persons enjoying various rights.

Throughout history, diverse cultures have given diverse answers to the mind–body problem. A twenty-first-century controversy about the mind–body problem could result in cultural and political splits more consequential even than the split between Jews and Christians or between Catholics and Protestants. What happens, for example, if the American sphere discounts the body, defines humans by their online identity, recognises AIs as persons and downplays the importance of the ecosystem, whereas the Chinese sphere adopts opposite positions? Current disagreements about violations of human rights or adherence to ecological standards will look minuscule in comparison. The Thirty Years' War – arguably the most devastating war in European history – was fought at least in part because Catholics and Protestants couldn't agree on doctrines like *sola fide* and on whether Christ was divine, human or non-binary. Might future conflicts start because of an argument about AI rights and the non-binary nature of avatars?

As noted, these are all wild speculations, and in all likelihood actual cultures and ideologies will develop in different – and perhaps even wilder – directions. But it is probable that within a few decades the computer network will cultivate new human and non-human identities that make little sense to us. And if the world will be divided into two rival digital cocoons, the identities of entities in one cocoon might be unintelligible to the inhabitants of the other.

FROM CODE WAR TO HOT WAR

While China and the United States are currently the front-runners in the AI race, they are not alone. Other countries or blocs, such as the EU, India, Brazil and Russia, may try to create their own digital spheres, each influenced by different political, cultural and religious traditions.[37] Instead of being divided between just two global empires, the world might be divided among a dozen empires. It is unclear whether this will somewhat alleviate or only exacerbate the imperial competition.

The more the new empires compete against one another, the greater the danger of armed conflict. The Cold War between the United States and the USSR never escalated into a direct military confrontation largely thanks to